

What DBI's Permit Record Contains, and whether the projects that reach the Commission are different

Dan Post

September 2026

Abstract

The permit-linkage memo used DBI's Building Permits table as a lookup: find the permit the hearing was about and read off its outcome. This memo reads the table itself. It inventories every column from the rows rather than the documentation, describes the permit clock, defines a development-relevant universe, and asks the question the real-options frame needs answered before any linked outcome is interpreted: *do the projects that appear in the minutes look different from observably similar projects that do not?*

The table is mostly not about development. It holds 1,295,168 rows for 1,149,352 permits filed from 1901 to 2026; 76.6% of the permits are over-the-counter alterations. Under stated rules 57,883 permits — 5.0% — are development-relevant: new construction, demolition, site permits, and alterations that change the unit count or sit in the top 5% of their year's cost. 4,517 of them (7.8%) are Commission-linked, through a permit number printed in the minutes or the Planning records' own permit field.

Linked projects are bigger and slower, but most of the difference in time is immortal time. Their median estimated cost is \$350,000 against \$150,000; the standardised difference in log cost is 0.54 raw and 0.23 within cells of permit type, filing period and neighbourhood. From filing to issuance they take a median 500 days against 191, a standardised difference of 0.71 raw and 0.43 within cells. But a permit linked through a hearing held while it was pending had to survive to that hearing and could not issue before it. Measured from the hearing forward, on permits alive at it, the standardised difference is 0.04 — about 9% of the within-cell gap survives, 28% of it in medians. The lower abandonment of linked permits does survive: 20.9% expired or withdrawn against 31.7% (-0.16 within cells), and -0.24 after the hearing.

The developer's clock on the DR track starts well before the Planning record does. From the filing of the permit a discretionary review is about to the first DR hearing is a median 294 days; from the opening of the Planning record the data-acquisition memo used, 101. On the cases with both, the permit clock is a median 150 days longer.

Contents

1	What is in the table	3
2	Types, statuses, and the permit clock	11
3	A development-relevant universe	11
4	Three linkage tiers, kept apart	15
5	Are Commission projects different?	15

6	Immortal time: the comparison from the hearing forward	16
7	Three targeted comparisons	17
8	Bunching at the thresholds	17
9	The developer's clock on the DR track	19
10	Caveats	19
11	Established, and not established	20
12	Reproducing this	20

1 What is in the table

The source is DataSF’s *Building Permits* (i98e-djp9), fetched in full — every column the resource endpoint returns — on 2026-09-11. The permit-linkage memo’s cache held twenty-two chosen columns, which suited matching permit numbers and does not suit a question about what the record contains. The full fetch has 57 columns: 4 Socrata system fields and 53 data columns. The download paged on the system row identifier rather than on an offset, so a daily update landing mid-download cannot shift a page; 0 identifiers came back twice.

Table 1 gives every column’s kind, inferred from the values, its populated share overall and by the decade the permit was filed, and its number of distinct values. Table 2 gives the three most frequent values of each and, for 17 columns, the measurement showing that the rows do not deliver what the column’s name promises. The ones that matter for this project:

- **record_id** is DBI’s own identifier. None of its values has the shape of a Planning case or record number; the name invites a join that does not exist.
- **first_construction_document_date** — the permit memo’s “construction started” — is filled on 1.2% of permits and is effectively absent before the late 1990s, and its fill rate on new construction moves with the era (Table 2). A “construction started” share would measure the field, not construction, so **it is not used as an outcome anywhere in this memo**; an earlier version reported one, in the permit clock and the comparison. (That version’s field notes also listed the column’s most frequent value as one midnight timestamp, which read as a placeholder; it held a few dozen rows and led only because timestamps were counted as strings. Dates are now counted by calendar day.)
- **estimated_cost** carries placeholder values: 10.2% of filled rows are \$1 or less. **They are dropped from every cost comparison below**, as missing rather than as a cost. Dated correction (2026-09-11): the previous version logged them as zero, and reported standardised differences in log cost of 0.43 raw and 0.19 within cells. In the two comparison groups they are 1.8% of linked and 2.0% of unlinked permits. The universe’s cost rule is a within-year percentile computed with them in the denominator; they can never pass it.
- The one-valued flags — **site_permit**, **structural_notification**, **fire_only_permit**, **reroof**, **primary_address_flag** — record only Y. A blank means “no” or “not recorded”, and the table cannot say which.

Table 1: Every column of the Building Permits table as it is actually filled: the share of rows with a value, overall and by the decade the permit was filed, and the number of distinct values. ‘Kind’ is inferred from the values, not the documentation.

Field	Kind	All	<1980	1980s	1990s	2000s	2010s	2020s	Distinct
:id	system	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,295,168
:created_at	system	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	316
:updated_at	system	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	318
:version	system	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,295,168
permit_number	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,149,358
permit_type	code	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	9

Field	Kind	All	<1980	1980s	1990s	2000s	2010s	2020s	Distinct
permit_type_definition	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	8
permit_creation_date	date	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	103,230
block	code	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	5,242
lot	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,578
street_number	code	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	5,940
street_number_suffix	text	1.0	1	1	1	1	1	2	25
street_name	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,965
street_suffix	text	98.8	99	100	99	98	99	99	24
unit	number	11.5	13	10	9	10	14	13	1,186
unit_suffix	text	0.8	0	0	0	1	1	1	353
description	text	98.6	86	88	100	100	100	100	806,523
status	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	23
status_date	date	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	543,143
filed_date	date	99.9	100	100	100	100	100	100	791,153
issued_date	date	95.0	86	91	97	97	95	92	766,198
completed_date	date	57.8	16	70	54	52	58	65	252,956
first_construction_date	date	1.2	0	0	0	2	2	0	12,932
approved_date	date	95.2	88	94	98	97	95	87	760,114
structural_notification	flag	4.0	4	7	4	4	3	3	1
number_of_existing_stories	code	84.1	17	87	98	76	78	90	136
number_of_proposed_stories	code	79.2	24	82	78	76	77	90	146
voluntary_soft_story_retrofit	flag	0.0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1
fire_only_permit	flag	4.2	0	0	0	0	9	13	1
estimated_cost	number	88.9	79	98	99	83	80	97	38,813
revised_cost	number	69.4	1	4	9	98	98	98	40,837
existing_use	text	86.9	17	87	98	84	79	95	99
existing_units	number	80.5	16	85	96	76	72	80	629
proposed_use	text	86.2	21	86	97	83	78	94	99
proposed_units	number	81.6	26	94	97	75	72	80	636
plansets	number	90.1	100	100	100	85	80	97	15
tidf_compliance	text	0.1	3	0	0	0	0	0	4
existing_occupancy	text	86.5	30	85	96	84	78	96	4,123
proposed_occupancy	text	87.2	42	94	97	83	78	95	4,818
existing_construction_type	code	79.1	2	80	78	76	77	90	6
existing_construction_type_description	text	79.1	2	80	78	76	77	90	5
proposed_construction_type	code	78.9	3	82	77	76	77	90	11
proposed_construction_type_description	text	78.9	3	82	77	76	77	90	5
site_permit	flag	2.4	6	0	3	3	3	1	1
last_permit_activity_date	date	92.3	4	63	83	100	100	100	770,130

Field	Kind	All	<1980	1980s	1990s	2000s	2010s	2020s	Distinct
application_submission_method	text	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	3
adu	flag	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	2
primary_address_flag	flag	88.7	83	86	86	88	91	92	1
supervisor_district	code	99.7	96	99	100	100	100	100	11
neighborhoods_analysis_boundaries	text	99.7	96	99	100	100	100	100	41
zipcode	code	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	30
location	geometry	99.7	96	99	100	100	100	100	165,124
point_source	text	99.7	96	99	100	100	100	100	2
reroof	flag	9.0	0	0	15	9	7	13	1
record_id	code	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	1,295,168
data_as_of	date	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	310
data_loaded_at	date	100.0	100	100	100	100	100	100	310

Table 2: The three most frequent values of every column, and where the rows do not deliver what the column's name promises, the measurement that shows it.

Field	Most frequent values	What the rows deliver
:id	row-wauk.mkk3-gckg; row-xq6s.i3xf-zu6u; row-se43.buxg_jd5r	
:created_at	2025-08-07T19:01:07.429Z; 2025-09-19T18:00:27.535Z; 2025-12-17T12:38:37.287Z	
:updated_at	2025-08-08T10:43:49.464Z; 2026-01-11T12:54:43.122Z; 2026-01-25T12:42:22.649Z	
:version	rv-9k3i jnx8 8m39; rv-zjxp_gwts-tey6; rv-vyud.w9y9-kc6c	
permit_number	201602179765; 201602179758; 201602179775	
permit_type	8; 3; 4	
permit_type_definition	otc alterations permit; additions alterations or rep; sign - erect	
permit_creation_date	2017-09-15; 1991-08-30; 2015-11-03	the same day as filed_date on 99.7% of rows
block	3708; 3709; 0289	
lot	001; 007; 006	
street_number	1; 101; 50	
street_number_suffix	A; V; B	filled on 0.99% of rows
street_name	Market; California; Mission	
street_suffix	St; Av; Bl	
unit	0; 1; 2	
unit_suffix	A; B; C	filled on 0.83% of rows
description	reroofing; street space; street space permit	
status	complete; issued; expired	

Field	Most frequent values	What the rows deliver
status_date	1983-03-04; 2026-01-09; 1986-03-04	
filed_date	2017-09-15; 1991-08-30; 2015-11-03	
issued_date	2016-06-15; 2018-10-02; 2016-07-26	
completed_date	1983-03-04; 1986-03-04; 1992-05-13	filled on 100.0% of permits with status 'complete'
first_construction_document_date	2016-11-07; 2016-11-01; 2006-11-09	on issued new-construction permits: filled on 0.05% of those filed in the 1980s, 11.9% in the 1990s, 69.6% in the 2000s
approved_date	2018-10-02; 2016-06-14; 2016-07-26	
structural_notification	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 4.0% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
number_of_existing_stories	2; 3; 1	
number_of_proposed_stories	2; 3; 1	
voluntary_soft_story_retrofit	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 0.01% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
fire_only_permit	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 4.2% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
estimated_cost	1.0; 5000.0; 10000.0	\$1 or less on 10.2% of filled rows; the most frequent value is \$1
revised_cost	1.0; 0.0; 5000.0	filled on 3.6% of permits filed in the 1980s, 98.3% in the 2010s
existing_use	1 family dwelling; apartments; office	
existing_units	1.0; 0.0; 2.0	filled on 94.4% of additions and alterations (blank on new construction, where nothing exists)
proposed_use	1 family dwelling; apartments; 2 family dwelling	
proposed_units	1.0; 0.0; 2.0	filled on 97.6% of new-construction permits
plansets	2; 0; 3	
tidf_compliance	Y; R; P	filled on 0.07% of rows
existing_occupancy	R-3; R-1; R-2	
proposed_occupancy	R-3; R-1; R-2	
existing_construction_type	5; 1; 3	
existing_construction_type_description	wood frame (5); constr type 1; constr type 3	
proposed_construction_type	5; 1; 3	
proposed_construction_type_description	wood frame (5); constr type 1; constr type 3	

Field	Most frequent values	What the rows deliver
site_permit	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 2.4% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
last_permit_activity_date	1960-01-01; 2018-10-02; 2016-06-22	
application_submission_method	in-house; website; epr website	
adu	N; Y	
primary_address_flag	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 88.7% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
supervisor_district	3; 8; 2	
neighborhoods_analysis_boundaries	Financial District/South Bea; Mission; Sunset/Parkside	
zipcode	94110; 94114; 94117	
location	POINT (-122.394985937 37.793; POINT (-122.403518141 37.792; POINT (-122.398125294 37.791	
point_source	eas_address_point; parcel_centroid	
reroof	Y	a flag with one value (Y) on 9.0% of rows; blank means no, or not recorded
record_id	1410598100118; 141060174315; 1410604404163	not a Planning record: 0.0% of values have a case-number shape; DBI's own identifier
data_as_of	2025-08-07; 2026-01-11; 2026-01-25	
data_loaded_at	2025-08-08; 2026-01-11; 2026-01-25	

Table 3: Permits by type and filing decade, one row per permit number (the earliest-filed row of each).

Permit type	before 1980	1980s	1990s	2000s	2010s	2020s	no filed date	All
(type 9, undefined)	0	0	0	0	0	555	89	644
additions, alterations or repairs	217	72,026	74,191	47,919	21,892	8,813	412	225,470
demolition	1	1,668	1,450	1,672	1,002	434	26	6,253
grade or excavate	0	103	167	208	135	55	4	672
new construction	24	576	264	332	584	176	12	1,968
new construction, wood frame	14	3,767	3,154	2,214	1,235	455	35	10,874
over-the-counter alterations	3	37,621	144,500	251,014	306,443	139,967	426	879,974
sign — erect	2	4,363	3,470	3,715	5,333	2,894	6	19,783
wall or painted sign	0	655	1,001	744	913	398	3	3,714
All	261	120,779	228,197	307,818	337,537	153,747	1,013	1,149,352

Table 4: Status, one row per permit. The exits — expired, withdrawn, cancelled, disapproved, revoked, suspended — are the trace of a project that did not proceed.

Status	Permits	Share
complete	658,548	57.3%
issued	224,334	19.5%
expired †	203,029	17.7%
cancelled †	38,199	3.3%
filed	10,451	0.9%
withdrawn †	9,778	0.9%
reinstated	1,330	0.1%
approved	952	0.1%
filing	920	0.1%
suspend †	575	0.1%
disapproved †	491	0.0%
triage	401	0.0%
revoked †	221	0.0%
plancheck	43	0.0%
appeal	23	0.0%
issuing	23	0.0%
(blank)	12	0.0%
denied	8	0.0%
inspection	4	0.0%
incomplete	3	0.0%
unknown	3	0.0%
upheld	2	0.0%
granted	1	0.0%
overruled	1	0.0%

Table 5: The permit clock by type and filing decade: the share reaching each stage, and the median days between stages among permits that reached both. Negative intervals are excluded from the medians and counted in the text. Recent decades are right-censored.

Type	Filed	Permits	Issued	Filed → issued		Completed	Issued → done	Exited
				median	p90		median	
new construction (types 1, 2)	1980s	4,343	85.4%	177	527	68.7%	335	29.9%
	1990s	3,418	87.5%	278	1,245	68.3%	400	29.0%
	2000s	2,546	80.0%	410	1,475	61.9%	573	30.2%
	2010s	1,819	74.5%	437	1,533	55.3%	941	15.3%
	2020s	631	42.3%	453	1,090	13.3%	792	9.4%
additions and alterations (3)	before 1980	217	87.6%	74	706	12.4%	2,598	78.8%
	1980s	72,026	87.7%	36	155	65.3%	144	33.8%
	1990s	74,191	91.6%	37	182	56.2%	135	43.0%
	2000s	47,919	88.6%	51	315	56.1%	194	35.8%
	2010s	21,892	79.8%	223	734	60.2%	381	21.8%
demolition (6)	2020s	8,813	69.1%	225	717	39.2%	328	11.5%
	1980s	1,668	86.3%	39	265	73.4%	102	24.8%
	1990s	1,450	87.0%	177	573	66.3%	152	23.4%
	2000s	1,672	76.9%	279	1,154	55.3%	182	28.1%
	2010s	1,002	82.0%	234	1,129	62.9%	351	13.1%
over-the-counter (8)	2020s	434	62.4%	148	841	38.7%	153	6.0%
	1980s	37,621	97.9%	0	0	77.7%	85	22.4%
	1990s	144,500	99.8%	0	0	53.2%	69	47.2%
	2000s	251,014	99.1%	0	0	51.0%	85	23.4%
	2010s	306,443	96.7%	0	22	57.9%	105	5.9%
	2020s	139,967	93.9%	0	60	68.2%	101	5.3%

Table 6: The development-relevant universe, rule by rule, over the 269,378 permits that are not over-the-counter alterations. ‘Alone’ is what the rule keeps by itself; ‘added’ is what it adds to the rules above it. The cost rule is the top 5% of additions-and-alterations estimated cost within the filing year; the sensitivity rows swap it for the alternatives.

Rule	Alone	Added
new construction	12,842	12,842
demolition	6,253	6,253
site permit	26,146	19,477
alteration changing units	12,219	9,355
alteration over the cost threshold	11,697	9,956
Universe		57,883
of which Commission-linked (T1 or T2)		4,517
of which T3 only		1,773
Over-the-counter permits excluded	879,974	
<i>Sensitivity: the cost rule replaced by</i>		
top 10%	67,041	6.8% linked
top 2%	51,871	8.6% linked
nominal \$1M	50,315	9.0% linked

Table 7: The linkage tiers. Items is item-table rows that reach at least one permit by the tier; permits is distinct DBI permits reached, all and within the development-relevant universe. T3’s precision was measured on discretionary reviews, where the printed number is ground truth, and is unmeasured elsewhere.

Tier	Items	Permits	In the universe
T1: permit number printed in the minutes	3,515	2,239	1,890
T2: Planning records’ building permits	7,864	5,518	4,042
T3: parcel + type + window	6,664	8,427	3,615
T1 and T2 both		1,627	1,415
Commission-linked (T1 or T2)		6,130	4,517

Table 8: Commission-linked permits against development-relevant permits no tier reaches. Standardised difference is the difference in means over the pooled standard deviation; ‘cells’ reweights the unlinked group to the linked group’s distribution over permit type $\times$ 5-year filing bin $\times$ analysis neighbourhood (97.3% of linked permits have a counterpart cell), ‘units’ over type $\times$ bin $\times$ unit-count bin (99.7%). T3-only permits are in neither group.

Variable	Linked		Not linked		Std. difference		
	mean	median	mean	median	raw	cells	units
estimated cost (log)	12.79	12.77	11.63	11.92	0.54	0.23	0.16
estimated cost (\$)	6,257,088	350,000	788,881	150,000	0.29	0.10	0.07
revised cost (log)	13.14	13.12	12.04	12.07	0.54	0.26	0.18
existing units	4.0	1.0	11.4	1.0	-0.09	-0.08	-0.09
proposed units	21.6	2.0	11.2	1.0	0.12	0.07	-0.02
net units	3.6	0.0	-0.4	0.0	0.07	0.14	0.09
existing stories	2.5	2.0	5.3	2.0	-0.37	-0.11	-0.15
proposed stories	4.5	3.0	5.5	3.0	-0.10	0.07	0.01
filing year	2011	2010	2001	2000	0.98	0.02	0.02
existing use: one-family dwelling	26.2%		32.7%		-0.14	0.00	0.01
existing use: apartments	6.8%		11.3%		-0.15	-0.01	-0.01
proposed use: one-family dwelling	26.5%		32.9%		-0.14	-0.06	-0.01
proposed use: apartments	24.1%		16.0%		0.20	0.07	-0.01
proposed use: office	2.8%		11.8%		-0.35	-0.05	-0.02
proposed use: retail	1.7%		2.3%		-0.04	0.06	0.06
construction: wood frame	60.2%		68.4%		-0.17	-0.01	0.01
construction: type 1	11.9%		13.0%		-0.03	0.04	-0.02
zoning at filing: C-3 (downtown)	4.2%		3.1%		0.06	0.01	0.03
zoning at filing: NC / NCT (neighbourhood commercial)	11.3%		3.2%		0.32	0.04	0.04
zoning at filing: RH (house)	48.4%		33.6%		0.30	-0.06	-0.00
zoning at filing: RM (mixed)	10.6%		4.5%		0.23	0.04	0.05
outcome: issued	78.7%		81.5%		-0.07	0.13	0.13
outcome: days filed to issued	689.5	500.0	303.4	191.0	0.71	0.43	0.44
outcome: completed	53.2%		56.8%		-0.07	0.05	0.03

Variable	Linked		Not linked		Std. difference		
	mean	median	mean	median	raw	cells	units
outcome: expired or withdrawn	20.9%		31.7%		-0.25	-0.16	-0.13

Table 9: Outcomes within unit-count bins: linked against unlinked permits with the same number of proposed units, the unlinked group reweighted to the linked group’s type $\times$ filing bin $\times$ neighbourhood distribution. Bins with fewer than twenty linked permits are omitted.

Proposed units	Linked	Unlinked	Support	Issued		Days to issue		Expired or withdrawn	
				linked	unlinked	linked	unlinked	linked	unlinked
1	1,208	17,019	95.9%	82.6%	82.4%	712	438	29.2%	29.1%
2–4	1,127	13,047	92.2%	78.8%	68.4%	773	484	24.6%	35.4%
5–9	170	2,000	78.2%	57.1%	57.3%	786	446	21.8%	28.4%
10–19	152	1,370	66.4%	81.2%	82.4%	712	607	25.7%	23.8%
20–49	204	1,018	57.8%	77.1%	68.7%	631	461	14.4%	32.5%
50+	369	1,542	66.9%	79.8%	70.0%	534	401	9.7%	24.2%

2 Types, statuses, and the permit clock

Table 3 counts permits by type and filing decade, one row per permit number (§10 gives the collapse rule). Over-the-counter alterations dominate every decade from the 1990s; new construction is a small share throughout. Table 4 is the status distribution: the exits — expired, withdrawn, cancelled, disapproved, revoked, suspended — are marked, because they are the observable trace of a project that did not proceed.

Table 5 and Figure 1 give the clock: filed, issued, first construction document, completed, and the exits, by type and filing decade. Two features stand out. The time from filing to issuance for new construction has lengthened decade on decade; and every recent decade is right-censored — a permit filed in 2024 has not had time to be completed or to expire — so its completion and exit shares are floors, not rates. 0.18% of permits show an issuance before their filing; they are excluded from the medians rather than trimmed from the table.

3 A development-relevant universe

The question of whether Commission projects differ is not a question about kitchen remodels. Table 6 builds the comparison universe rule by rule and reports what each keeps: new construction of every construction type, demolitions, site permits, and additions or alterations that either change the dwelling-unit count or have an estimated cost in the top 5% of additions and alterations filed the same year. Over-the-counter alterations are excluded outright. The cost rule is a within-year percentile so that it means the same thing in 1985 and in 2025; a nominal threshold tilts the universe toward recent years, when nominal costs are higher. The sensitivity rows show the universe under the top 10% and top 2% and under a nominal \$1 million, with the Commission-linked share of each. The universe holds 57,883 permits.

Table 10: Immortal time. ‘Raw’ and ‘within cells’ are Table 8’s rows. ‘Landmark’ keeps only permits alive at their hearing — for a linked permit the first linked hearing on or after its filing; for an unlinked permit a date its filing plus a lag drawn from the linked permits’ filing-to-hearing lags in the same cell — and measures from that date: days from the hearing to issuance, and the share issued or expired or withdrawn afterwards. Unlinked means and medians are reweighted to the linked cells (type $\times$ 5-year filing bin $\times$ neighbourhood; 97.1% of the linked landmark sample has a counterpart). The standardised difference in brackets is its range over 5 draws of the lags.

	Raw	Within cells	Landmark, within cells
<i>Days to issuance (issued permits)</i>	filing $\rightarrow$ issued	filing $\rightarrow$ issued	hearing $\rightarrow$ issued
linked, mean	690	690	408
unlinked, mean	303	444	390
linked, median	500	500	274
unlinked, median	191	303	219
standardised difference	0.71	0.43	0.04 [0.03, 0.06]
<i>Expired or withdrawn</i>			after the hearing
linked	20.9%	20.9%	23.7%
unlinked	31.7%	27.8%	34.5%
standardised difference	-0.25	-0.16	-0.24 [-0.26, -0.24]
<i>Issued</i>			after the hearing
linked	78.7%	78.7%	77.6%
unlinked	81.5%	73.8%	64.7%
standardised difference	-0.07	0.13	0.29 [0.29, 0.30]
<i>Samples</i>			
linked permits	4,517		3,354
unlinked permits	51,593		14,926

Table 11: Three targeted comparisons. In each, the first group is the one named; the second is reweighted to it over the cells shown (‘support’ is the share of the first group with a counterpart cell). The DR comparison is a proxy: the Planning records carry no §311 notification record, so it compares the permits a DR request named with the other major permits in residential districts, where notice applies.

	First group	Second, raw	Second, reweighted	Std. diff. raw	reweighted
<i>DR track (proxy): major permits a DR request named vs other major permits in residential districts filed 2006–2020; cells type $\times$ filing year $\times$ neighbourhood; 487 vs 22,268, support 94.9%</i>					
estimated cost (log)	12.41	10.97	11.42	0.86	0.54
proposed units	4	8	6	-0.17	-0.18
issued	81.5%	80.1%	80.0%	0.04	0.05
days filed to issued	947	368	486	1.01	0.76
completed	50.3%	58.5%	58.9%	-0.16	-0.17
expired or withdrawn	23.4%	24.2%	21.0%	-0.02	0.06
<i>CU track: CU-linked vs same proposed use and zoning district, no Commission link; cells use $\times$ zoning $\times$ filing bin; 1,685 vs 53,366, support 90.7%</i>					
estimated cost (log)	13.18	11.67	11.82	0.69	0.59
proposed units	29	12	25	0.20	0.04
issued	72.8%	81.5%	70.5%	-0.20	0.05
days filed to issued	698	304	467	0.65	0.37
completed	51.5%	56.8%	48.7%	-0.11	0.06
expired or withdrawn	14.9%	31.6%	25.9%	-0.40	-0.27
<i>Ministerial vs Commission, new construction filed 2018 on: SB 35 / SB 423 vs Commission-linked; cells unit bin; 31 vs 434, support 100.0%</i>					
estimated cost (log)	16.86	15.11	16.81	1.02	0.03
proposed units	111	44	135	0.70	-0.20
issued	64.5%	38.5%	44.4%	0.54	0.41
days filed to issued	425	709	530	-0.70	-0.28
completed	48.4%	14.1%	23.1%	0.80	0.55
expired or withdrawn	3.2%	7.1%	7.2%	-0.18	-0.18

Table 12: Permits at the unit counts around the thresholds. Counts, not shares; the figure gives the full distribution. The 25-unit line is the brief’s figure for the July 2026 ordinance and has not been checked against the ordinance here; permits filed in 2026 are too few to show a response to it.

Group	Filed	7	8	9	10	11	12	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27
all development-relevant	<2016	157	247	168	132	84	253	96	30	105	46	42	27	56	32	34	25
all development-relevant	≥2016	192	200	123	94	51	63	29	32	30	29	27	20	27	22	10	16
Commission-linked	<2016	9	19	17	12	17	16	10	5	17	6	4	7	11	3	7	4
Commission-linked	≥2016	12	12	11	5	5	4	4	2	4	4	1	1	9	5	0	2

Table 13: The developer’s clock on the DR track. ‘DBI’ runs from the filing of the permit the DR is about (reached by T1 or T2) to the first DR hearing; ‘Planning record’ from the opening of the case’s record, the clock the data-acquisition memo used, to the same hearing. One row per DR case.

Clock	Cases	p25	Median	p75	p90	Negative
DBI permit filed → first hearing	2,356	183	294	498	791	3.0%
Planning record opened → first hearing	2,418	70	101	169	315	0.4%
DBI clock, cases with both	2,269	183	296	509	798	2.5%
Planning clock, cases with both	2,269	71	101	169	315	0.4%
difference (DBI – Planning)	2,269	68	150	338	623	8.9%

Table 14: The DR cases whose linked permit was filed after the Planning record opened (the negative differences in Table 13), by why. ‘Planning date from another record’: the case number has no DR record of its own and the clock fell back to the earliest record sharing its stem. ‘Permit through a sibling or parent record’: a T2 link read from another record sharing the stem, not from the DR record itself or the minutes. ‘The DR’s own permit’: printed in the minutes (T1) or named by the DR record, and filed after the request opened. ‘On the item’s parcel’: the permit’s block and lot are among the item’s.

Why	Cases	On the item’s parcel
Planning date from another record	76	68
Permit through a sibling or parent record	15	13
The DR’s own permit, filed after the request	110	102
All	201	183

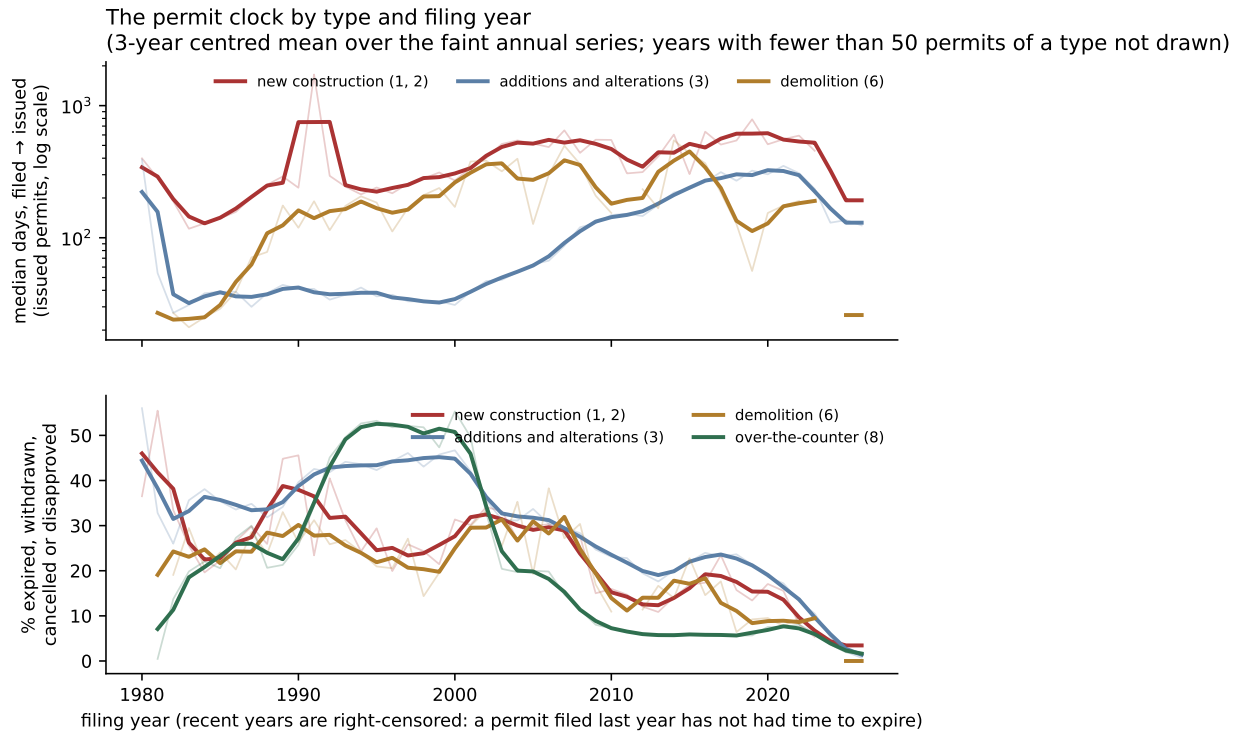


Figure 1: Top: median days from filing to issuance, by permit type and filing year, among issued permits; over-the-counter permits are issued the day they are filed and are drawn in the lower panel only. Bottom: the share of each year's permits that expired, were withdrawn, cancelled or disapproved. Faint lines are annual values; bold lines a 3-year centred mean; years with fewer than 50 permits of a type are not drawn. The last years are right-censored in both panels: the permits filed then that are already issued are the fast ones, and the rest have not had time to expire.

4 Three linkage tiers, kept apart

Table 7 gives the tiers:

- **T1**, a permit number printed in the minutes, parsed and matched exactly as in the permit-linkage memo: 2,239 permits.
- **T2**, the Planning Department records’ `building_permits` field, read through the case, its parent project record and every record sharing its stem, as in the data-acquisition memo’s bridge: 5,518 permits. 1,627 are reached both ways.
- **T3**, the parcel + type + window rule — a major permit filed at the item’s parcel between three years before and one year after the hearing. Its precision of 0.72 and recall of 0.92 were measured on discretionary reviews, where the printed number is ground truth, and are unmeasured anywhere else.

“**Commission-linked**” means **T1 or T2**. T3 returns candidate sets whose error rate outside discretionary review is unknown, so T3-only permits — 1,773 of them in the universe — are reported as their own group and never pooled with either side of a comparison.

5 Are Commission projects different?

Table 8 compares the 4,517 Commission-linked permits in the universe with the development-relevant permits no tier reaches. Each row gives means and medians and the standardised difference three ways: raw; after reweighting the unlinked group to the linked group’s distribution over cells of permit type $\times$ 5-year filing bin $\times$ analysis neighbourhood (97.3% of linked permits have a counterpart cell); and after reweighting over type $\times$ filing bin $\times$ unit-count bin (99.7%). Table 9 repeats the outcome comparison within unit-count bins.

- **Era is the first difference, and cells remove it by construction.** Linked permits were filed on average in 2011 against 2001: both linkage routes reach recent permits better than old ones. Every raw difference in the table is partly this.
- **Scale.** Linked permits cost more: 0.54 standard deviations in log cost raw, 0.23 within cells, 0.16 within unit-count cells. Proposed units differ by 0.12 raw and 0.07 within cells. Some of the gap is where and when; the rest is that a project large enough to need a hearing is large.
- **Time.** Filing to issuance is where the linked group stands apart: 0.71 raw, 0.43 within cells and 0.44 within unit-count cells. Table 9 shows the gap in every unit-count bin. **Most of it is mechanical:** §6 measures from the hearing forward and the gap all but disappears.
- **Abandonment.** Linked permits expire or are withdrawn less often (20.9% against 31.7%; -0.16 within cells), and this one survives the landmark comparison. A project that has been through a hearing has sunk more by the time it holds a permit, and a project that would be abandoned may be abandoned before it ever reaches one.
- **Use and place.** Linked permits are more often apartments and less often offices or one-family dwellings, and more often in residential-house and neighbourhood-commercial districts at filing; within cells these differences mostly vanish, because the cells hold place and type fixed.

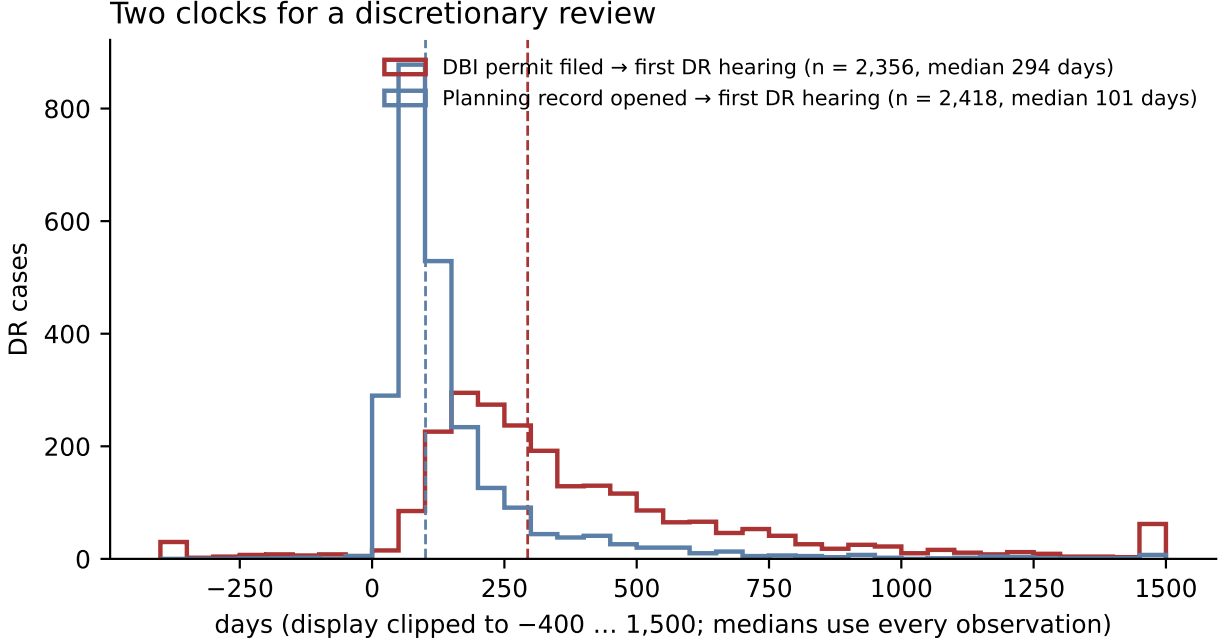


Figure 2: The two clocks on the discretionary-review track, one observation per DR case. The display is clipped; the medians use every observation.

6 Immortal time: the comparison from the hearing forward

“Commission-linked” is defined by a hearing, and for most linked permits the hearing fell while the permit was pending. Such a permit had to survive to the hearing, and could not issue before it; an unlinked permit carries no such condition. So part of the linked group’s longer filing-to-issuance time and of its lower abandonment is mechanical — guaranteed by how the group is defined — rather than a difference between projects.

Table 10 removes it with a landmark. For a linked permit the landmark is the first linked hearing on or after its filing; 3,587 linked permits have one, and 923 were filed after every hearing they are linked to (their survival was not conditioned on a hearing; they are left out rather than given a date). An unlinked permit has no hearing, so it is given one: its filing date plus a lag drawn at random from the linked permits’ filing-to-hearing lags in the same cell of type, filing period and neighbourhood (the median linked lag is 320 days). Both groups are then kept only if still pending at their landmark — filed, not issued, completed, expired or withdrawn by it — which leaves 3,354 linked and 14,926 unlinked permits, and every outcome is measured from the landmark. The unlinked group is reweighted to the linked group’s cells as before (97.1% support), and the draw is repeated 5 times to show how much it moves the result.

How much of the headline gap survives. In days to issuance, little. The standardised difference in means is 0.71 raw, 0.43 within cells, and 0.04 (between 0.03 and 0.06 across draws) from the hearing forward — about 9% of the within-cell gap. Medians keep more of it: within cells a linked permit’s median is 197 days longer (500 against a reweighted 303); from the hearing it is 55 days longer (274 against 219), about 28% of the within-cell median gap — the typical linked permit is still somewhat slower after its hearing, while the means, which the long tails of both groups dominate, barely differ. **Most of the longer filed-to-issued time of Commission-linked permits is the time before the hearing that the definition of the group guarantees, not**

a slower passage after it. Abandonment is the opposite: linked permits alive at their hearing expire or are withdrawn afterwards 23.7% of the time against 34.5% for unlinked permits alive at the matched date, a standardised difference of -0.24 against -0.16 within cells. That gap does not come from immortal time. What it does come from — a project that has come through a hearing being further committed, or the unlinked permits still pending at a year’s lag being a slower, weaker set — this comparison does not say.

The targeted comparisons in the next section measure days from filing, and are subject to the same mechanism; they have not been re-anchored.

7 Three targeted comparisons

Table 11 gives three narrower comparisons, each reweighted over the cells it names.

The DR track, as a proxy. The brief asked for noticed permits that drew a DR request against noticed permits that did not. **The Planning records do not identify §311 notification records:** no record type is a notice, and the text mentions notice mostly to say it was not required. What the records do identify is the DR request, whose description names its permit from 2015–2020; 646 of the 693 requests opened in those years do, and 487 of the named permits are major permits in DBI. They are compared with the other major permits filed 2006–2020 in residential districts, where notice applies. That is a comparison of permits that drew a DR request against permits that could have, not against permits known to have been noticed, and it is labelled a proxy wherever it appears.

The CU track. Permits linked to a conditional use, against development-relevant permits of the same proposed use in the same zoning district at filing, in the same filing period, with no Commission link.

Ministerial against Commission, 2018 on. New construction approved under SB 35 — flagged on 76 project records — or SB 423, which has no field and is found in 45 records only by its name in the text, reaches 31 permits in DBI, against 434 Commission-linked new-construction permits of the same period, reweighted over unit-count bins. The ministerial group is too small for its percentages to carry weight, and the table says so by giving the counts.

8 Bunching at the thresholds

Figure 3 and Table 12 give proposed units from 1 to 40 for every development-relevant permit and for the Commission-linked ones, before and after 2016 (Proposition C raised the inclusionary requirement that year). The lines mark the inclusionary threshold at 10 units, the Transportation Sustainability Fee’s residential tiers — which begin, as the fee register prints them, at 21, 100 units — and 25 units, the brief’s figure for the July 2026 ordinance, which this memo has not checked against the ordinance and which too few 2026 permits exist to test.

Read as counts, the distribution has visible heaping at round numbers in both periods, and the counts just below and just above each threshold are in Table 12 so the reader can judge. No bunching estimate is attempted here: the counts near any single threshold are in the tens, the Commission-linked counts in single digits, and a proposed unit count on a permit is not the same object as the count at entitlement.

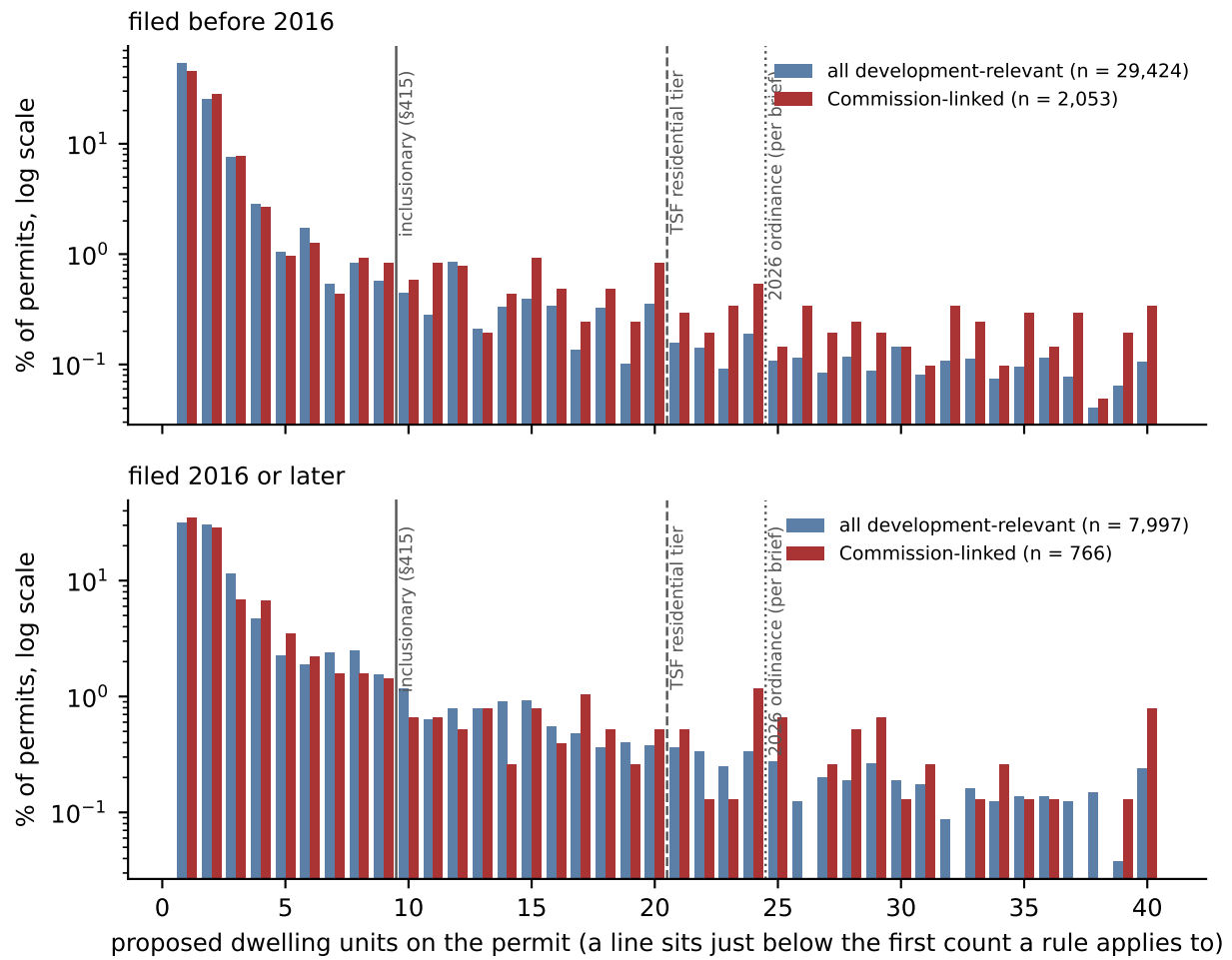


Figure 3: Proposed dwelling units on development-relevant permits, 1 to 40, as a share of each group, on a log scale; before and after 2016. The solid line sits just below the inclusionary threshold, the dashed lines below the TSF residential tiers, the dotted line below the brief’s 2026 threshold.

9 The developer’s clock on the DR track

The data-acquisition memo measured filing to first hearing from the opening of the Planning record. For a discretionary review that record is the DR request — filed by a neighbour against a pending permit — so the clock starts when the neighbour acts, not when the developer does. Table 13 and Figure 2 measure the developer’s clock instead: from the DBI filing of the permit the review is about, reached by T1 or T2, to the first DR hearing. On 2,356 of the 2,524 DR cases it is a median 294 days with a 90th percentile of 791; the Planning-record clock on 2,418 cases is a median 101 with a 90th percentile of 315. On the 2,269 cases with both, the developer’s clock is a median 150 days longer. 3.0% of the developer’s clocks are negative — the linked permit was filed after the first hearing — and they are kept rather than trimmed.

Where the permit comes after the request. On 8.9% of the cases with both clocks (201) the difference is negative: the linked permit was filed after the Planning record opened. A neighbour files a DR request against a pending permit, so this should not happen, and Table 14 sorts the cases by why. For 76 the Planning date is not the DR request’s: the case number has no DR record of its own, and the clock fell back to the earliest record sharing its stem — a record-type issue in the Planning clock, not a mislink. For 15 the permit was reached only through a sibling or parent record sharing the stem (a T2 stem link to another phase, parcel or revision), 2 of them off the item’s parcel. The largest group, 110, is the DR’s own permit — printed in the minutes or named by the DR record — filed after the request opened; the data do not say why (a revision permit filed after the original drew the request is one possibility). So **the negative differences are mostly not T2 stem mislinks**: 15 of 201. Across all three groups 18 permits sit off the item’s parcel.

10 Caveats

- **Duplicate permit numbers.** 145,816 rows repeat a permit number already in the table, spread over 116,986 permits — one row per lot a permit touches. Every count here is on one row per permit, the earliest filed. DBI marks one row per permit itself (`primary_address_flag`); the two rules pick the same row for 94.6% of permits, and the choice barely matters for what is compared here: type, cost, units, dates and status differ between a permit’s rows for at most 0.01% of the permits that repeat.
- **T3 is unvalidated outside discretionary review**, and is never pooled.
- **Coverage rises with era.** Both Commission-linkage routes reach recent permits better than old ones, which is why every comparison is repeated within filing-period cells.
- **Linked does not mean the permit the hearing was about.** T2 in particular reads every record sharing a case stem, so a large project’s linked set can include permits for other phases or parcels of the same project. The comparison is of permits connected to a Commission case, not of the single permit each hearing decided.
- **The unlinked group is not a control group.** It is the set of development permits no route reaches, which includes Commission projects whose link is missing. If the missing links resemble the found ones, the differences are understated rather than overstated; either way they are descriptions, not effects.

11 Established, and not established

Established.

1. The table's 57 columns, their fill by decade, and 17 columns whose rows do not deliver what the name suggests, including the absence of construction-start dates before the late 1990s.
2. A development-relevant universe of 57,883 permits under stated rules, reported beside three alternative cost rules.
3. Commission-linked development permits take longer from filing to issuance than similar unlinked permits in the same place, period and type, by 0.43 standard deviations — but measured from the hearing forward, on permits alive at it, by 0.04 (a median gap of 55 days against 197): **the gap in time is mostly immortal time**. They are larger, and less often abandoned, and the abandonment gap survives the landmark (-0.24).
4. The developer's clock on the DR track runs a median 150 days longer than the Planning-record clock. Of the 201 cases where the permit postdates the Planning record, 15 are T2 links through a sibling or parent record; 76 take the Planning date from another record and 110 are the DR's own permit.

Not established.

1. Anything causal. The within-cell differences describe who reaches the Commission; they do not say what the hearing did.
2. Why linked permits alive at their hearing are abandoned less afterwards: commitment, or the composition of the unlinked permits still pending at the matched date.
3. The landmark comparison for the targeted DR, CU and ministerial comparisons, which still measure from filing.
4. Which of a linked set is the permit the hearing decided.
5. The §311 comparison as the brief framed it: notices are not in the records.
6. Whether the ministerial group, at 31 permits, is large enough to say anything.
7. Any response to the 2026 threshold.

12 Reproducing this

```
python analyze_permit_content.py fetch           # every column, resumable
python analyze_permit_content.py fetch --refresh # re-download
python analyze_permit_content.py report          # figures, tables, macros
```

`fetch` pages DataSF's Building Permits on the system row identifier into one file per page under `$MFHR_DATA_ROOT/external/datasf/dbi_full_parts/` and stacks them into `dbi_permits_full.csv.gz`, with its retrieval time and column list beside it. `report` imports the printed-permit parser, the parcel rule and its window from `analyze_permits.py`, and the case normalisers, the planning records and the `building_permits` bridge from `acquire_external_data.py`;

it joins the zoning district in force at filing from the parcel-year panel, reads the fee register for the TSF tiers, and writes the three figures, `tables/permits_content_tables.tex` and `tables/permits_content_macros.tex`. The linkage tiers are cached beside the DBI file and rebuilt whenever it is newer. The only numerals typed into the `.tex` are section references, identifiers, the twenty-two columns of the earlier cache, and the legal facts named as such (Proposition C, SB 35, SB 423, §311, the 1985 and 2025 of an example).